Reasoning Ability

BankPrep AI | Banking Exam Preparation Study Material
Version 3.0 | Last verified: 9 October 2026

1. Number Series

Look for a pattern involving addition, subtraction, multiplication, division or squares.

Question: 2, 4, 8, 16, __. Answer: 32. Each number is multiplied by 2.

Question: 5, 10, 17, 26, __. Answer: 37. The increments are 5, 7, 9 and 11.

2. Coding and Decoding

Letters may be replaced by letters a fixed number of positions forward or backward.

Question: If CAT becomes DBU by shifting each letter forward by one, how does DOG change? Answer: EPH.

3. Direction Sense

North is opposite South. East is opposite West.

Question: A person walks 3 km north and then 4 km east. How far are they from the starting point? Answer: 5 km, using the 3-4-5 right triangle.

4. Syllogisms

Use only the information given in the statements. Do not assume facts that are not stated.

Statements: All roses are flowers. All flowers are plants. Conclusion: All roses are plants. Answer: Follows.

5. Alphabet Series

Question: A, C, E, G, __. Answer: I. Each letter advances by two positions.

Question: Z, X, V, T, __. Answer: R.

6. Practice Questions

Q1. 3, 6, 12, 24, __. Answer: 48.

Q2. If PEN is coded as QFO, how is CAT coded? Answer: DBU.

Q3. A person faces north and turns right. Which direction are they facing? Answer: East.

7. What Changed in Reasoning Questions (2026)

The reasoning syllabus is the same, but the weight of topics has shifted heavily toward puzzles and critical thinking. Practice questions in this file are original, written in the style of questions reported in recent exams. They are not actual exam questions.

SBI PO Prelims 2026: candidates reported about 25 of the 30 reasoning questions came from puzzles. These included a tricky selection-based puzzle with 11 persons and month-based puzzles with variables, plus a few blood relation and number-based questions. Syllogism and inequality were reported absent in the shifts reviewed.

SBI PO Mains 2026 (12 September): reported about five major puzzles (month-date, floor with variables, circular, box, city-person table, linear and parallel-row seating), about 8 to 10 critical reasoning questions, 3 data sufficiency questions with two statements (floor, parallel row and direction based), and one question each of decision making, cause and effect, and conclusion-based reasoning.

IBPS PO Prelims 2026 (22 and 23 August): about five sets of puzzles and seating in some shifts, with miscellaneous topics such as syllogism, inequality, coding-decoding, blood relations and direction sense in others.

IBPS PO Mains 2026 (4 October): puzzles, seating arrangements, critical reasoning (strengthening, weakening, assumptions, inference and conclusion), machine input-output, syllogism and data sufficiency.

SBI Clerk Prelims 2026 (26 and 27 September): about 10 puzzle questions, seating arrangement, week-based puzzles, alphanumeric series, blood relations, inequality and Chinese coding (about 5 questions in one shift). Overall difficulty was easy to moderate.

8. Linear Arrangement Puzzle (solved)

Six friends P, Q, R, S, T and U sit in a row facing north (positions 1 to 6 from the left). Q sits at an extreme end. P sits second to the right of Q. R sits immediately to the right of P. S sits between Q and P. T sits to the right of R but not at an extreme end.

Solution: Q must be at position 1 (an extreme end with someone to the right). P is at 3, R at 4, S at 2 and T at 5, so U is at 6. Arrangement: Q S P R T U.

Q1. Who sits at the extreme right? Answer: U. Q2. Who sits immediately to the left of T? Answer: R. Q3. How many persons sit between Q and R? Answer: Two (S and P).

9. Floor-Based Puzzle (solved)

Five persons A, B, C, D and E live on five different floors of a building numbered 1 (lowest) to 5 (top). D lives on floor 1. B lives immediately above C. A lives above B but not on the top floor. E lives on the top floor.

Solution: D = 1 and E = 5. A must be on 4 (above B, not on top), so B and C occupy floors 2 and 3, and B is immediately above C: C = 2 and B = 3. Order from bottom: D, C, B, A, E.

Q1. Who lives on floor 3? Answer: B. Q2. How many floors are between C and A? Answer: One (B's floor).

10. Month-Based Puzzle (solved)

Five friends P, Q, R, S and T were each born in a different month among February, March, April, May and June of the same non-leap year. S was born in a month with fewer than 30 days. R was born in the month immediately after Q. T was born in an earlier month than Q. P was born in a month with 30 days. Nobody was born between the months of P and R.

Solution: S = February. R is immediately after Q with T before Q, so Q cannot be March. Using the 30-day condition on P and the no-one-between condition with R gives S = February, T = March, Q = April, R = May, P = June.

Q1. Who was born in May? Answer: R. Q2. How many persons were born between T and P? Answer: Two (Q and R). Q3. Who was born immediately before Q? Answer: T.

11. Circular Arrangement Puzzle (solved)

Six persons A, B, C, D, E and F sit around a circular table facing the centre. A sits opposite D. B sits between A and C, as an immediate neighbour of both. E is not an immediate neighbour of D. F sits opposite B.

Solution: The neighbour order around the table is A, B, C, D, F, E (and back to A), or its mirror image; both give the same neighbour and opposite relationships.

Q1. Who sits opposite C? Answer: E. Q2. Who sits between D and E? Answer: F. Q3. Who sits opposite D? Answer: A.

12. Selection-Based and Variable Puzzles (approach)

Selection-based puzzles (for example 11 persons where some are selected for a task) and variable puzzles (floor plus colour or month plus date) are time-consuming. Approach: (1) draw a table with rows for persons and columns for each variable; (2) place definite statements first; (3) use two-case branching only when needed and note which case dies first; (4) skip a set that needs more than three cases in Prelims and attempt it later in Mains.

13. Critical Reasoning

Critical reasoning is now a major scoring area in SBI PO Mains and IBPS PO Mains. Common types: assumption, strengthen, weaken, inference and conclusion.

Assumption. Q1. Statement: The bank has decided to open more branches in rural areas to increase its customer base. Assumptions: I. People in rural areas currently have limited access to banking services. II. All urban customers will shift to rural branches. Answer: Only assumption I is implicit.

Strengthen. Q2. Argument: Since UPI transactions have risen sharply this year, customer visits to bank branches must have fallen. Which statement strengthens it? (A) Banks have opened new branches in cities. (B) A survey found most customers now use UPI instead of visiting branches. (C) UPI is operated by NPCI. (D) Branch staff strength was increased. Answer: (B).

Weaken. Q3. Argument: The repo rate has been raised, so the EMI of every home loan borrower will rise. Which statement weakens it? (A) Many borrowers hold fixed-rate loans whose rate does not change with the repo rate. (B) The repo rate is set by the RBI. (C) Home loans are offered by banks. (D) EMI means equated monthly instalment. Answer: (A).

Inference. Q4. Statement: Every account holder who completed KYC could use the new service. Rina is an account holder but could not use the new service. Which conclusion definitely follows? Answer: Rina did not complete KYC.

14. Data Sufficiency in Reasoning

Options: (a) Statement I alone is sufficient; (b) Statement II alone is sufficient; (c) either alone is sufficient; (d) both together are needed; (e) even both together are not sufficient.

Q1. Who is the tallest among P, Q and R? I. P is taller than Q. II. R is shorter than Q. Answer: (d). Together P > Q > R, so P is the tallest. Neither alone settles it.

Q2. Who sits at the extreme left of a row of four persons W, X, Y and Z facing north? I. Y sits at the extreme right. II. X sits to the immediate left of Y. Answer: (e). Y at the right and X next to Y still leaves W and Z in the left two seats, so it cannot be decided.

15. Decision Making, Cause and Effect, Conclusion Based

Course of action. Q1. Statement: Customer complaints about delayed UPI refunds have increased. Courses: I. The bank should set up a faster dispute-resolution system. II. The bank should stop offering UPI. Answer: Only course I follows.

Cause and effect. Q2. Statements: I. The RBI increased the repo rate. II. Banks announced higher interest rates on loans linked to the repo rate. Answer: Statement I is the cause and statement II is its effect.

Conclusion based. Q3. Statement: All loans are liabilities for the borrower. Some liabilities are secured. Conclusions: I. Some loans are secured. II. Some liabilities are loans. Answer: Only conclusion II follows.

16. Syllogism and Inequality

These still appear in IBPS PO Prelims and clerk-level exams.

Syllogism. Q1. Statements: All banks are institutions. Some institutions are old. Conclusions: I. Some banks are old. II. Some old are institutions. Answer: Only conclusion II follows.

Inequality. Q2. Statements: P >= Q > R = S; S < T. Conclusions: I. P > S. II. T > R. Answer: Both follow. P >= Q > R = S gives P > S. R = S < T gives T > R.

17. Coding: Chinese Coding, Shift Coding and Alphanumeric Series

Chinese coding. Q1. In a code, 'bank loan rate' is written 'ka mo si', 'rate hike' is written 'si dem' and 'bank deposit rate' is written 'ka vo si'. How is 'bank hike' written? Answer: 'rate' is the common word in the first two codes, so rate = si. Then bank = ka and hike = dem. 'bank hike' = 'ka dem'.

Shift coding. Q2. In a code BANK is written DCPM (each letter moved 2 places forward). How is LOAN written? Answer: NQCP.

Alphanumeric series. Q3. B3, D7, F11, H15, __. Answer: J19. Letters move 2 forward and numbers rise by 4.

18. Machine Input-Output

Rule: In each step the largest remaining number is moved to the left end, then the smallest to the right end, then the second largest to the second position, then the second smallest to the second position from the right, and so on.

Input: 25 84 17 53 91. Step I: 91 25 84 17 53. Step II: 91 25 84 53 17. Step III: 91 84 25 53 17. Step IV: 91 84 53 25 17.

Q1. What is Step II? Answer: 91 25 84 53 17. Q2. How many steps are needed to reach the final arrangement? Answer: Four.

19. Blood Relations and Direction Sense (new style)

Blood relation. Q1. Pointing to a man, Rina said, 'He is the son of my mother's only brother.' How is the man related to Rina? Answer: Cousin (her maternal uncle's son).

Direction. Q2. Ravi walks 5 km north, turns right and walks 3 km, then turns right again and walks 5 km. How far and in which direction is he from the starting point? Answer: 3 km to the east.

20. Computer Aptitude (SBI PO Mains and Clerk Mains)

SBI PO Mains and SBI Clerk Mains combine reasoning with computer aptitude. Basics worth knowing: 1 byte = 8 bits. RAM (Random Access Memory) is volatile memory. A printer is an output device. URL means Uniform Resource Locator. In Windows, Ctrl + C copies selected text, Ctrl + V pastes it and Ctrl + Z undoes the last action.

Q1. Which of these is volatile memory? Answer: RAM. Q2. How many bits are in one byte? Answer: 8. Q3. Which shortcut pastes copied text in Windows? Answer: Ctrl + V.